

Pahankanuwa Sermon #16

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Suppabuddhaṃ pabujjhanti, sadā gotamasāvakā; Yesaṃ divā ca
ratto ca, niccaṃ buddhagatā sati. Suppabuddhaṃ pabujjhanti, sadā
gotamasāvakā; Yesaṃ divā ca ratto ca, niccaṃ dhammagatā sati.
Suppabuddhaṃ pabujjhanti, sadā gotamasāvakā; Yesaṃ divā ca
ratto ca, niccaṃ saṅghagatā sati. Suppabuddhaṃ pabujjhanti, sadā
gotamasāvakā; Yesaṃ divā ca ratto ca, ahimsāya rato mano.
Suppabuddhaṃ pabujjhanti, sadā gotamasāvakā; Yesaṃ divā ca
ratto ca, bhāvanāya rato mano.*

From:

Verses 296-301 from the Bhikkhuvagga (Chapter on the Monk) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

On this Esala Full Moon Poya day, what is recalled to us is the correct view, the Right View (*Sammā-diṭṭhi*), regarding life, which the Buddha placed before gods and humans. On that day, in the *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta*, the very first step of the Noble Eightfold Path—the Middle Path placed before the world by the Buddha—was Right View (*Sammā-diṭṭhi*). Today, we have chosen as our theme a few verses that demonstrate and express the relief, happiness, solace, and protection that one can obtain in daily life through life-practices arising from that Right View and aligned with it.

These verses were preached by the Buddha during the time he was residing at the Veluvana Monastery in the city of Rājagaha. The background story that led to this is presented in the following manner:

In the city of Rājagaha, a child from a family of Right View and a child from a family of wrong view got together and regularly played a game of marbles. "Marbles game" (*guḷa-krīḍā*) refers to a certain ball game that existed in those days. While playing this game, every time the child of Right View threw the ball, he would say *"Namo Buddhassa"* (Homage to the Buddha). The child of the wrong-view family would throw the ball saying *"Namo arahantānaṃ"* (Homage to the Arahants), which meant paying homage to the heretics. When playing like this, the wrong-view child won, and the other one lost. The other child (the wrong-view one) thought, "Now, my friend wins because he recollects the Buddha," and so he himself began to practice the recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*).

While this child was practicing the recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*), one day, the child's father took the child, yoked the cart, and went to the forest to gather firewood. Having loaded the wood onto the cart in the morning, around noon, near a cemetery outside the city, he unyoked the cart and had some food. Meanwhile, the two oxen joined other cattle heading towards the city and entered inside. After finishing his meal, when the cart-driver looked around, the oxen were gone. Therefore, he entered the city to search for them. By the time he found the two oxen and started to return, it was evening and the city gates had closed. Because of this, the man was unable to come back out. Thus, the little child fell asleep under the cart.

Since it was near the cemetery, there were many non-human beings (*amanussa*). There were two *yakkhas*—one *yakkha* of right view, meaning he was devoted to the Triple Gem, and the other *yakkha* of wrong view. The two of them saw this child. The wrong-view *yakkha* said, "Here is a good meal, let us eat." The other one tried to prevent him. However, he pulled the child by the leg. As soon as he pulled, the child cried, *"Namo Buddhassa!"* Immediately upon hearing this, the *yakkha* was frightened and froze. Then, the other *yakkha* said, "We have committed a great wrong. Therefore, we must undergo punishment for this." The two of them together guarded the child throughout the night and provided protection. Moreover, the wrong-view *yakkha* went to the royal palace and brought back food in a golden vessel. Arriving in the night, they disguised themselves as the child's parents, fed him, and kept watch. After the child ate, the *yakkha* used his psychic power to engrave some letters on the vessel, stating: "May only the King see this"—explaining how this vessel came to be here. Having done this, they placed the vessel in the cart and vanished.

Then, in the morning, the palace staff, finding the vessel missing, searched around. Having checked inside the city, they came outside, and upon spotting the cart, they searched it and saw the golden vessel. Seeing it, they arrested the child,

thinking he was the thief. Subsequently, when he was brought before the King along with the vessel, the King saw the lettering and asked, "What is the story behind this?" The child replied, "I do not know. Throughout the night, my mother and father came, gave me food, and protected me. That is all I know." At that moment, the child's actual parents also arrived. The King, together with the child and his parents, went to the Buddha. They went and related this news. Then, the King asked the Buddha: "Is it only through this recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*) that one truly receives protection, or are there other things as well?" It was on that occasion that the Buddha preached these six verses, showing that if one directs one's mind in these six ways within one's life, and maintains such thoughts, that person requires no special protections, nor any mantras. This itself is a great protection; it was to demonstrate this point that those verses were uttered. Let us next consider the general meaning of those verses.

"Suppabuddham pabujjhanti, sadā gotamasāvakā; yesam divā ca ratto ca, niccam buddhagatā sati."

The meaning of this verse is that the disciples of Gotama who constantly, both day and night, develop the recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*) and recollect the qualities of the Buddha, always awaken in the morning fully refreshed and joyful. It is in the exact same manner that the subsequent verses speak: *"Suppabuddham pabujjhanti..."* Those who develop the recollection of the Dhamma (*Dhammānussati*), who contemplate the Dhamma, likewise awaken in the morning fully refreshed and joyful. The next verse deals with the recollection of the Saṅgha (*Saṅghānussati*). Those who develop the recollection of the Saṅgha also awaken fully refreshed and joyful.

Next, it is said that those who develop mindfulness directed to the body (*kāyagatā-sati*)—mindfulness that follows the body—also awaken in the morning fully refreshed and joyful. The next verse states:

"Suppabuddham pabujjhanti, sadā gotamasāvakā; yesam divā ca ratto ca, ahimsāya rato mano."

If any disciples of Gotama, throughout day and night, delight in non-violence (*ahimsā*) and maintain thoughts accustomed to harmlessness, they awaken fully refreshed and joyful.

Next, it is stated:

"Suppabuddham pabujjhanti, sadā gotamasāvakā; yesam divā ca ratto ca, bhāvanāya rato mano."

If any disciples of Gotama live delighting in meditation (*bhāvanā*) both day and night, they awaken fully refreshed and joyful.

Here, there is a small point to be made. Now, in the commentaries, regarding the interpretation of those last-mentioned verses, the books state that "delighting in non-violence" (*ahimsāya rato mano*) refers to the meditation on compassion (*karuṇā-bhāvanā*), and "delighting in meditation" (*bhāvanāya rato*) refers to the meditation on loving-kindness (*mettā-bhāvanā*). In this way, they restrict the meaning. However, we think it is more reasonable to take "delighting in non-violence" (*ahimsāya rato mano*) as maintaining thoughts accustomed to harmlessness, such as loving-kindness and compassion, rather than as a specific, separate meditation on compassion. Next, we think that "delighting in meditation" (*bhāvanāya rato mano*) can be more meaningful if taken generally as having a mind inclined toward meditation. Why? Because the standard sequence mentioned is loving-kindness (*mettā*), compassion (*karuṇā*), appreciative joy (*muditā*), and equanimity (*upekkhā*). It is difficult to think that compassion would be mentioned first here, followed by loving-kindness. It is far more meaningful and broader in scope to understand "delighting in non-violence" (*ahimsāya rato mano*) as conducting one's thoughts in accordance with non-violence, and "delighting in meditation" as spending one's daily life with a mind inclined toward meditation.

In any case, through these six verses, the Buddha placed before the world the way to awaken refreshed and joyful, so as to spend the day in an excellent manner. What is demonstrated by this story is the protection obtained through the recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*) and its immensely powerful nature. Every single person in this merit-seeking gathering knows that the Triple Gem—namely, the Buddha-gem, the Dhamma-gem, and the Saṅgha-gem—indeed exists as a protective mantra for everyone. What is the reason for this? The quality of the Buddha-gem is suffused throughout the universe. Through the power of the Buddha's perfections (*pāramīs*), the Buddha-quality has been infused into the universe. Because of this, there is a natural law (*dhammatā*) whereby some protection is provided through contemplating the qualities of the Buddha. This is clearly visible to us from the Buddha's own words. In the *Dhajagga Sutta*—which is also known as the *Dhajagga Paritta*—the Buddha directly declares: "Monks, when you go into forests, to the roots of trees, or to empty dwellings to practice meditation, if any fear, terror, or hair-standing-on-end should arise, at that moment, contemplate the Tathāgata—that is, recollect me. Recall me with this passage: *'Itipi so bhagavā araham sammāsambuddho...'*" When you do so, whatever fear, terror, or hair-standing-on-end there was will disappear. If you do not contemplate me, if you do not recall me, then

contemplate the Dhamma with the passage starting with *'Svākkhāto...'* Even then, that fear will disappear. If not even that, then recall the Saṅgha with *'Supaṭipanno...'*." In this way, the Buddha himself declares in the **Dhajagga Sutta**.

You have all heard of the **Ratana Sutta**, where, based on the power of the Triple Gem, the three great fears (including the fear of non-humans) in the city of Visālā were dispelled by chanting as a **paritta**—which means protection—declaring the qualities of the Buddha, the qualities of the Dhamma, and the qualities of the Saṅgha. From this, we can clearly see that recollection of the Buddha (**Buddhānussati**), recollection of the Dhamma (**Dhammānussati**), and recollection of the Saṅgha (**Saṅghānussati**) can be regarded not only as meditations but also as protective chants (**paritta**). As a **paritta**, it yields protection for oneself. This is exactly what is shown in this story as well. Though he was a child of a wrong-view family, having seen a child of Right View practicing recollection of the Buddha and gaining its benefits, he became accustomed to **Buddhānussati**. From then on, the benefit came naturally; almost spontaneously, when a disaster strikes, there is a tendency for the accustomed meditation subject (**kammaṭṭhāna**) to be uttered. Even nowadays, perhaps because the Buddhist imprint is deeply embedded in our nation, when a mishap occurs, people cry out *"Budu Amme"* (O Buddha Mother!). Generally, they do not just say *"Amme"* (Mother), they say *"Budu Amme"*. The Buddha is remembered. Similarly, here, as soon as the child recalled the Buddha saying *"Namo Buddhassa"*, the **yakkha** became terrified of the Buddha-quality, the Buddha-majesty. Thus, we can see the power within the recollection of the Buddha—its power as a protection. Furthermore, here, the Buddha states by the term **suppabuddham** that it helps one to awaken refreshed and joyful. That is to say, if one lives through the day with a mind well-directed towards the Buddha-qualities, one receives immense solace.

From this series of verses, we must primarily focus our attention on the recollection of the Buddha (**Buddhānussati**), which almost everyone knows and practices. There is something special to be said about it. The other subjects we will also have to mention briefly according to the available time. If we consider the meditation on the recollection of the Buddha, everyone knows the nine qualities of the Buddha. It is on the basis of the text of these nine qualities that one develops the recollection of the Buddha. Either one recites the entire passage of the nine qualities, or there is also a method of expressing each quality in detail, with expositions. Such a method of developing **Buddhānussati** has existed for a long time. However, it seems to us that when one tries to analyze each word in that manner, the mind tends to get scattered. Now, the nine qualities of the

Buddha in the *kammaṭṭhāna* portion for *Buddhānussati* are presented like this:

"Itipi so bhagavā araham sammāsambuddho vijjācaraṇasampanno sugato lokavidū anuttaro purisadammasārathi satthā devamanussānaṃ buddho bhagavā."*

Here, nine qualities are mentioned. There is a habit of taking each of these and explaining them in various scholarly ways. Some people even consider going through their etymologies, explaining them, and repeatedly reciting them as the actual meditation. However, one must consider that there must be a specific distinction, a difference, between reading a book written about the Buddha's qualities and meditating on those qualities. If it is a book written on the Buddha's qualities, then yes, by reading detailed and very beautiful passages, there is an opportunity to develop a wholesome mind. However, a deep concentration (*samādhi*) is not obtained; the mind becomes scattered therein. Instead, what is expected in the recollection of the Buddha is indeed to plunge into each term and, through it, accustom oneself to seeing the Buddha. Nowadays, scholars often analyze the word *Araham* academically and, dragging in a multitude of indirect, far-fetched meanings beyond its primary sense, hand them over to the meditator, telling them to list them numerically as meaning this and that. Through this, the mind actually becomes scattered, and it is difficult to think that the mind becomes unified. The mind does not become concentrated (*samādhi-mat*). The purpose of meditation must be the concentration of the mind, its one-pointedness. A vast crowd of words, passages, and praises is not very relevant to that one-pointedness.

Instead, what should be done is to consider the simple, general meaning of each term and draw as close to it with one's heart as possible. Just as the young Prince Rāhula approached the Buddha and said, "Ascetic, even your shadow is pleasant to me," one must accustom oneself to seeing the Buddha through each of these terms, plunging deep into that very word. In that regard, only a basic understanding of the meanings of those words is necessary. To put it briefly, as appropriate to the context, the primary meaning of the word *Araham* is "worthy of offerings." By virtue of the greatness of the Buddha's qualities, because of his state of being worshipful, he is worthy of offerings. If one wishes, it is sufficient to think of him as a noble being worthy of being honored with both material offerings (*āmisā-pūjā*) and the offering of practice (*paṭipatti-pūjā*). Beyond that, various other meanings and additional commentaries are not relevant here.

Next, it is the same with *Sammāsambuddho*. "Fully Self-Enlightened" means that he himself—it is called knowledge (*ñāṇa*)—by his own Buddha-knowledge,

thoroughly unraveled the secret regarding *saṃsāra* and life, the Four Noble Truths. He himself fully understood those Noble Truths without the guidance or advice of any other teacher or person. It is that special characteristic that is contained within the word *Sammāsambuddho*.

Vijjācaraṇasampanno. Likewise, within the two words *vijjā* and *caraṇa*, there are two sides of the Buddha's vast store of qualities. Here, *vijjā* refers to the cognitive aspect consisting of insight-knowledges (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*), etc. The knowledge, the understanding in one's life, is one side. Next, conduct (*caraṇa*) is the other side. Here, the Buddha is complete in both of these aspects. There are some people in society who have great knowledge, but their conduct is worthless. Some conduct themselves well, but are weak in their capacity for understanding. Unlike them, the Buddha is complete in both. If *vijjā* is compared to the two eyes, and *caraṇa*—the *caraṇa-dhamma*—is compared to the two feet, he is complete in both of these limbs: both eyes and feet. He is complete in both of these foundational requirements for traversing this path of practice. Thus, through the quality *Vijjācaraṇasampanno*, one can understand that the Buddha is endowed with both of these dimensions.

Next, *Sugato* is also interpreted in various ways, such as "having an excellent gait" or "having good qualities," and so on. However, we should understand *Sugato* meaningfully: he went well along the path of practice, the path that must be traversed for the sake of Nibbāna. He brought that journey to an end; he reached the end of that journey. Precisely because he was endowed with those two aforementioned qualities of *vijjā* and *caraṇa*, the Buddha reached the end of that path of practice in the correct manner.

Furthermore, having reached there, his understanding of everything that ought to be known about the world is what is shown by the quality *Lokavidū*. This quality too can be interpreted in various ways, such as having understood everything that should be known about the world systems (*loka-dhātu*). However, it can be understood more clearly in this way: nowadays, many people understand the external world scientifically. But the Buddha did not merely understand the world in that manner; he understood the interior of each individual. He understood the individual's world. He also understood the external world that exists as the environment for the individual. Because the Buddha understood everything that needs to be known regarding this, he is called *Lokavidū* (Knower of the World).

Anuttaro purisadammasārathi. Then, relying on that very quality of *Lokavidū*, the Buddha, in taming individuals who are fit to be tamed, was like a charioteer—like an extremely skilled driver. The Buddha had the ability to

discipline anyone using both his wisdom (*paññā*) and the skillful means called compassion (*karuṇā*). This is that power of disciplining. To whom, where, in what manner, and by what kind of discourse one can be disciplined, became clearly apparent to the Buddha's Buddha-knowledge. Therefore, utilizing that *Lokavidū* quality, the Buddha possessed the capability to tame various beings, which is why he is called *Anuttaro purisadammasārathi* (Incomparable Charioteer of tameable men).

So likewise, *Satthā devamanussānaṃ* means he is the teacher not only of humans but of gods as well. Next, *Buddho* means, when considered generally, he is complete in all the aforementioned Buddha-qualities; just as he attained Buddhahood through his self-awakened knowledge (*sayambhū-ñāṇa*), he also possesses the power to make others understand. In the term *Bhagavā*, there is the meaning of "Blessed One," "Fortunate One." Within it lies the quality of fortune, the blessing, the majesty of fortune, which is seen in the Buddhahood attained through the Buddha's power of perfections (*pāramīs*), and in his store of qualities and wisdom.

When the nine qualities of the Buddha are briefly considered in that way, what is next to be done is to recite those nine qualities in sequence for a considerable time: *"Itipi so bhagavā araham sammāsambuddho vijjācaraṇasampanno..."* and so on. While reciting in this manner, one can choose for oneself the word that appeals most to one's heart, the one that one prefers. In making that choice, if one selects a particular word, one does not need to struggle to explain the reasons for it. Actually speaking, if one directs one's mind to those nine qualities for a reasonable time and, discarding those that do not appeal as much to the heart, reduces the nine to eight, eight to seven, seven to six, and so on, and selects a certain quality because it appeals to one's heart, one does not need to labor to explain *why* it appeals. It is just like when, in a very natural way, someone develops an affection due to a connection in past lives (*saṃsāric* connection); sometimes one thinks, "Oh, I do not know why, but this is the person who appeals to my heart, this is how it is for me." Even saying that is enough. If one can say, "I do not know why, but out of these nine qualities, this is the one that appeals to my heart," that is indeed the most natural selection. Through that, some aspect of the Buddha-qualities deposited in one's mind during past associations with Buddhas, seeing Buddhas, and hearing the Dhamma, is activated. That selection is based on that. That is why we say it is natural. It is when one chooses in this manner that it becomes like Prince Rāhula approaching the Buddha and saying, "Ascetic, even your shadow is pleasant to me." If one can see the Buddha through this single word—saying "This word is enough for me"—there is no need to weave further concepts around it. One does not need to keep

describing it, reciting various beautiful words and beautiful passages. Doing so only scatters the mind.

Just like dropping an anchor to keep a boat in a reservoir from drifting here and there or rocking from side to side, this mind must plunge into that quality. Having plunged in, one must accustom oneself to seeing the Blessed One through that quality. Once accustomed in this way, many words are not needed. If one has chosen *Bhagavā*, then while saying "Bhagavā, Bhagavā," or if it is *Arahaṃ*, while saying "Arahaṃ, Arahaṃ, Arahaṃ," one can arrive at concentration (*samādhi*) through it. One does not need to think about it in detail. Through that word, one sees the Buddha. Now, that child said *"Namo Buddhassa"*. That was an era when the Buddha was alive. Now, even though the Buddha is no longer living, these devout Buddhists can see his vast store of qualities with their mind. For the faithful one, the one possessing Right View (*Sammā-diṭṭhi*), the Buddha can be seen with the mind. Therefore, even a single word that helps in seeing him with the mind is sufficient. Meditating on that word continuously, without letting the mind wander elsewhere, is indeed the meditation on the recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati-bhāvanā*).

We spoke specifically about the recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*) because so many people practice and train in it. If there are any shortcomings in one's practice, and if one feels that what we have said is correct, one can adjust one's practice accordingly.

Now, we will mention the other meditations very briefly, according to the available time. As for the recollection of the Dhamma (*Dhammānussati*), you have also heard of it many times, although it is not as popular:

"Svākkhāto bhagavatā dhammo sandiṭṭhiko akāliko ehipassiko opanayiko paccattam veditabbo viññūhīti."*

Six qualities are mentioned here. The quality of *Svākkhāto* means that this Dhamma preached by the Buddha was well-preached, excellently preached. Here, "excellently preached" does not refer to the tone of the Buddha's voice, nor to the linguistic style of the preached words. If the Buddha preached targeting a certain goal, a certain supreme purpose, it was preached with a beautiful beginning, middle, and end so as to lead to that purpose. This is not something meaningless or without sense. This Dhamma yields results. *Svākkhāto* means it is well-preached: the practice leads appropriately to the result, and the practice is perfectly suited to the result. That it is preached well in its beginning, middle, and end is what is to be understood by the word *Svākkhāto*.

Next, *Sandiṭṭhiko* means that its results can be seen by oneself right here in this world, in this very life. Why? Because within this Dhamma of the Buddha is the path to eliminate the defilements of greed, hatred, and delusion (*lobha, dosa, moha*) existing in our mental continuum. Thus, if some portion of these is removed, to that extent, one can experience it for oneself right in this life. It is not something to be received only in a future world. The paths, fruits, and Nibbāna can be attained in this very life; it is not a Nibbāna to be attained only in the next life. For that reason, it is the quality of *Sandiṭṭhiko* (visible here and now).

Akāliko means yielding immediate results, without delay. This is also connected to the previous quality. If someone has a certain degree of greed, hatred, or delusion, that person suffers from a corresponding degree of heavy grief or mental defilement. If these are removed to some extent with the help of the Dhamma, the very moment they are removed, there is solace. That is *Akāliko*. Deeply, this is shown in the realization of the supramundane Dhamma regarding the supramundane path. There, path (*magga*) and fruit (*phala*) are spoken of as two things, yet one falls into the fruit immediately along with the supramundane path. The supramundane path refers to an extremely subtle state of concentration (*samādhi*) attained by proceeding through insight-knowledge (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*). Simultaneously with it, one falls into the fruit. That is the quality of *Akāliko*—the nature of yielding results without delay.

Ehipassiko means "come and see." Within "come and see" lies the idea that this Dhamma is something inviting one to put it into action. It demonstrates its practical nature. The Dhamma itself says, "Come and see; put me into practice and see." To such an extent, there is an amazing practicality in the Dhamma. It is according to this that it is called *Ehipassiko*.

Opanayiko is a somewhat deep word. There too, it should be understood as leading onward, as drawing someone in. There is such a quality in the Dhamma: a nature of leading one from one stage to another, where one thing is connected to the next. For example, when developing Right View (*Sammā-diṭṭhi*), almost without one's realizing it, right thought, wholesome thought arises. When that is developed, in accordance with it, wholesome speech is uttered. In that way, if one lives in a certain manner, if one lives in accordance with the Dhamma, there is a nature of automatically leading one to those respective states. That is what is meant by *Opanayiko* (leading onward). One is drawn forward, led onward, by the Dhamma. Such a quality exists in this Dhamma.

Paccattam veditabbo viññūhīti means this is a Dhamma of such a nature that it can be personally realized by the wise within their own mental continuums,

within their own minds. Ultimately, it is realized by oneself. It is such a store of qualities—six qualities—that are presented as the qualities of the Dhamma.

Next, as for the qualities of the Saṅgha, you have also heard them frequently:

"Supaṭipanno bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho, ujupaṭipanno bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho, ñāyapaṭipanno bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho, sāmīcipaṭipanno bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho, yadidaṃ cattāri purisayugāni aṭṭha purisapuggalā, esa bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho, āhuneyyo pāhuneyyo dakkhiṇeyyo añjalikaraṇīyo anuttaraṃ puññaṃ lokassaṃti."

Such is the passage.

Within this too, there are nine qualities. Thus, primarily, *Supaṭipanno* means that the Saṅgha-gem of the eight noble individuals has entered correctly and well upon the path of practice leading to Nibbāna, and is engaged in that practice. Next, to emphasize this even more strongly, they are called *Ujupaṭipanno*. The Noble Eightfold Path is a straight path. It means they have plunged straight, directly, and honestly into that path and are acting accordingly. Next, *Ñāyapaṭipanno* means they have systematically entered upon that path of practice, logically from one stage to another. Likewise, *Sāmīcipaṭipanno* means they are walking correctly, slanting towards Nibbāna. All of these refer to their practice.

Next, *yadidaṃ cattāri purisayugāni aṭṭha purisapuggalā esa bhagavato sāvakaśaṅgho* refers to the eight individuals—the eight noble ones (*ariyas*) who have reached the four paths and four fruits (*magga-phala*).

By virtue of that very store of qualities, the worshipful nature of those Saṅgha members is spoken of next. *Āhuneyyo* means being worthy of having the four requisites brought from afar to be offered. *Pāhuneyyo* means that if one has prepared food in one's home for relatives or guests, when they arrive on their alms-round, that food is fit to be offered to them because of their vast store of qualities. Likewise, *Dakkhiṇeyyo* means they are worthy of receiving even special offerings made out of belief in the fruits of kamma. *Añjalikaraṇīyo* means they are worthy of being worshiped with palms together, raised to the forehead.

Next, *Anuttaraṃ puññaṃ lokassaṃti* means they are like an incomparable field of merit for the world; by virtue of that store of qualities, they are a field of merit capable of yielding the highest benefits to the merit-seeking donors.

In that manner, a multitude of matters are spoken of there as the qualities of the Saṅgha. Thus, through this, the Buddha shows that even contemplating the Saṅgha through any of these words as the recollection of the Saṅgha (*Saṅghānussati*) serves as a protection for one's life and, as stated in those verses, becomes a cause for awakening refreshed and joyful. In short, the person who contemplates the Triple Gem is able to spend his daily life in a refreshed and joyful manner.

The next one mentioned there is mindfulness directed to the body (*kāyagatā-sati*). *Kāyagatā-sati* means recollecting the true nature of this body of ours. This too is presented in three ways. You have mostly heard about *kāyagatā-sati*. The Buddha compares this bodily cage to a bag open at both ends, filled with grains. Inside this, there are thirty-two impure body parts (*kuṇapa-kotṭhāsa*). What is spoken of here is contemplating those impure parts. In short, it is seeing the various parts of this body, from the hair of the head down to the soles of the feet, as impure and repulsive. It is called *manasikāra*—contemplating them under the aspect of repulsiveness (*paṭikūla-manasikāra*).

Next, closely related to this, something included within *kāyagatā-sati* itself, is the meditation on repulsiveness (*asubha-bhāvanā*). Ten types of repulsiveness (*dasa-asubha*) are mentioned. As soon as one dies, according to the ancient custom in India, the body was taken and cast into a cemetery. After being cast into the cemetery, ten different stages of the decay of that bodily cage are presented as subjects of meditation on repulsiveness (*asubha-kammaṭṭhāna*). The state of this body before many days pass—bloated, discolored, then infested with worms, filled with pus, and finally reduced to a skeleton—is shown in ten stages as the "tenfold repulsiveness." Contemplating these is what is meant. What is expected from all of these is the development of disenchantment (*nibbidā*) towards this body.

The attachment towards this body which exists powerfully within the saṃsāric being—this lust (*rāga*), this attachment towards one's own body as well as the bodies of others—is precisely what causes one to go on and on in *saṃsāra*. As long as there is attachment to this bodily cage, even if this bird departs from here, it willingly enters another cage once again. It departs from here having already conjured up a cage in accordance with its kamma. It is not exactly as one wishes; rather, a cage is conjured up in accordance with the kamma one has performed. Once it is created, what follows next is birth (*jāti*) along with decay (*jarā*), disease (*vyādhi*), and the fear of death (*maraṇa-bhaya*). Such is the saṃsāric condition.

Therefore, the Buddha shows that without developing disenchantment (*nibbidā*) towards this bodily cage, one cannot escape from this *saṃsāra*. One cannot realize Nibbāna while maintaining attachment to it. Thus, whether we like it or not, whether lay or ordained, anyone who hopes to realize Nibbāna must, to some extent, develop mindfulness directed to the body (*kāyagatā-sati*).

Kāyagatā-sati is not something strange. We do not like to exhibit the real, true condition of our body externally. However, we must contemplate it in our mind. The Buddha has shown not only the things inside the body but also everything external as repulsive. Indeed, there is a repulsive nature. Yet, we cover them up. The world has no understanding of them due to defilements. The repulsive nature of this body endowed with consciousness (*viññāṇa*) is what is found in the aforementioned meditation on repulsiveness. It is contemplating what is inside this living body, like in a bag open at both ends. Next, similarly, there is the state that comes after it dies; that is the future. Contemplating that "this body too is subject to that same natural law, this body is of such a nature," attributing it and comparing it to oneself—through that too, one becomes disenchanted with the body. The understanding arises that "if this is something that rots, then maintaining pride (*māna*) regarding it as something superior, as we tend to think, is sheer foolishness." Such is the meditation on repulsiveness (*asubha-bhāvanā*).

In the exact same manner, another subject that comes up is what is called the "meditation on the elements" (*dhātu-kammaṭṭhāna*). This also helps in developing equanimity (*upekkhā*) regarding this body, establishing a certain equanimity free from attraction and aversion. That is, thinking of this body as something composed of four elements. There is no difference between our bodies and those of others when considered as elements. These bodily cages of ours, every single one of them, are things made of what we generally take as examples: the great earth, water, fire, and wind—namely, *paṭhavī, āpo, tejo, vāyo*. Contemplating in this way in terms of elements, the Buddha shows, helps particularly the wise to quickly develop equanimity towards the body. In short, for the realization of Nibbāna, through this meditation on the elements, a disenchantment with all four elements must arise in the mind at some point. The mind must be liberated from these four elements.

Why? Because that aforementioned cage is created out of these four elements. It is from these four elements—earth, water, fire, and wind (*paṭhavī, āpo, tejo, vāyo*)—that this bodily cage is created, just like kneading clay to build a house. It is created because of the attachment one has towards them. Within us, there is a subtle form of attachment toward these four elements. It was in order to eliminate this that the Buddha taught the elements. There are two ways of doing this.

One considers this living body itself. Hard things like hair, body hair, nails, teeth, etc., represent the earth element (*paṭhavī-dhātu*). Proof of the earth element exists in my body: in the form of hair, body hair, nails, teeth, and so on. The water element (*āpo-dhātu*) comprises things of a liquid, watery nature, such as phlegm, mucus, blood, pus, urine, and so forth; these too exist in my body as parts belonging to that element. Similarly, the fire element (*tejo-dhātu*) is in this body. Through the occurrence of fevers, the digestion of food in the body, the body's warmth, heat, and so on, the fire element is also within. Likewise, what is called the wind element (*vāyo-dhātu*)—this breathing-in and breathing-out of ours, the air that moves here and there within the body—all of these belong to the wind element. These are the four elements.

Next, one contemplates: "These four elements inside and the four elements outside are one and the same." Whether they are inside or outside, when viewed as elements, they are identical. Then, gradually, this also helps in eradicating the conceit (*māna*) of "I" and "mine." Empty pride and the like disappear when one contemplates: "Is it not these very same four elements that exist in everyone's body?" In this manner, the Buddha presents this mindfulness directed to the body (*kāyagatā-sati*). When this is contemplated, it brings great solace in daily life. The agitations arising from life's problems can be largely eliminated. What is done through this *kāyagatā-sati* is seeing the reality of life. If one sees the reality of life, one is not tempted to commit suicide. One understands the brevity of one's life according to the nature of this body. Such are the benefits of *kāyagatā-sati*.

Likewise, *ahimsāya rato mano* refers to non-violence (*ahimsā*). The commentary interprets this by restricting it solely to the meditation on compassion (*karuṇā-bhāvanā*). However, we can understand that non-violence is spoken of here directly as an attitude: delighting in non-violence, being inclined to non-violence, loving non-violence. The Buddha shows that delighting in non-violence is something extremely valuable. Mostly, what exists in the world is delighting in violence. The world always seeks to satisfy its own needs by harming others. If someone builds an inner attitude of not harming any being, therein lies both loving-kindness and compassion—not compassion alone. Looking at things with an attitude of loving-kindness and compassion is what is meant here by "delighting in non-violence." If one practices that in daily life, one can awaken refreshed and joyful. A strength comes to awaken refreshed and joyful, without regrets, if thoughts of non-violence, loving-kindness, and compassion are maintained in daily life.

Next, *bhāvanāya rato* is mentioned, which we took generally as an inclination toward meditation. An inclination toward meditation is also a valuable thing.

What is called meditation (*bhāvanā*)? It is the true development of the mind. In this day and age, various kinds of development of the mind are spoken of—certain developments through science, technology, etc. Development through education is spoken of. However, the development achieved through meditation as shown by the Buddha is something far more special. It is the path leading to Nibbāna. If there is any meditation that must be done to cross over this *saṃsāra*, it is being inclined to that very meditation. There, generally, meditation (*bhāvanā*) means the development of the mind—developing the mind as an inclination. Understanding its value and spending the day giving priority to it is a valuable thing.

So, from that, we can see that the Buddha has highlighted six life-values through these six verses: recollection of the Buddha (*Buddhānussati*), recollection of the Dhamma (*Dhammānussati*), recollection of the Saṅgha (*Saṅghānussati*), mindfulness directed to the body (*kāyagatā-sati*), non-violence (*ahimsā*), and lastly, a general inclination towards meditation, a love for meditation. That is to shape our lives. In short, we know that in this day and age, particularly, the majority of people in this society fall asleep in distress, awaken in distress, and live their lives in distress. That distressing condition arises because daily thoughts are maintained in an incorrect manner. Now, there is no need to tell you, who direct your minds through various media, how daily life is spent, how day and night are spent. Especially, how the night is spent. There is no need to tell you with what kind of things, with what kind of thoughts and wishes, it is spent. You can obtain proof for yourselves as to whether one can truly awaken refreshed and joyful through those, and whether one can spend the day mindfully (*satimant*) and happily. However, if one chooses one of these six channels based on the six values and six themes shown by the Buddha, and conducts one's thoughts and wishes accordingly, then just as the Buddha promises here, one can awaken in the morning *suppabuddham*—highly refreshed and joyful—spend the day joyfully, and spend the day peacefully. Along with that, a development of the mind occurs at the same time.

Therefore, from this, we can understand this multitude of values shown here by the Buddha. We must bring these close to our lives. More and more, we go towards the mouth of ruin because we have no correct understanding of the true core virtues and values of life. Why? Because the Buddha shows that this human mind we have received is extremely rare. In this mind, there is a capability, a strength, that can be developed towards Buddhahood. But what do we do? In an extremely dangerous manner, enticed and dragged away by the values presented through various modern pomps and modern science, we destroy our lives through them. We spend the day through media that defiles our thoughts and wishes. Instead, the Buddha indicates that, without any extra expense, without

any cost at all, to shape one's own life, to awaken refreshed and joyful in the aforementioned manner, and thereby to spend the entire day peacefully, one should make an effort to generate those very series of thoughts within one's own mental continuum.

Now, usually, a person thinks of meditation as something done only when sitting cross-legged. However, here, the Buddha specifically highlights **Anussati**—which means recollection. Now, from that story too, it is seen that the child did not know anything about the quality of **Araham**, etc., in depth, as stated in books. But he might have seen the Buddha. In any case, having generated a feeling and faith toward the Buddha, the moment he said **"Namo Buddhassa"*, the **yakkha** became terrified. We must think in that manner. We must draw close to this Buddha-quality just as Prince Rāhula drew close. Not through scholarly academic learning, with a multitude of long words and passages—even a single one is sufficient. What is the reason for this? We cannot develop it regularly in our daily lives as if we are reading a book. Now, it is said here: **"yesaṃ divā ca ratto ca, niccaṃ buddhagatā sati."** That disciple of Gotama develops the recollection of the Buddha constantly, both day and night. So, to develop recollection of the Buddha constantly, how can one develop it with such a vast collection of passages, alongside the duties of daily life? But if someone considers these briefly—let us say, as mentioned, the quality of **Araham** is highly pleasing to someone, or the quality of **Bhagavā** is highly pleasing to someone, having chosen it well by directing the mind for a considerable time, orienting the mind to the nine qualities.

Why do we call that a natural law (**dhammatā**)? Now, if we take an example: **Anuttaro purisadammasārathi** means "like an extremely skilled charioteer in taming beings." That word might appear very long. Yet, it can appeal to some people. Why? There could be a *sāmsāric* reason for it. In the past, during the time of the Buddha, when the Buddha was performing the taming of Aṅgulimāla, demonstrating his Buddha-power, it might be due to the faith one generated upon seeing that. In that manner, if some quality naturally appeals to our heart, recollecting that quality briefly is indeed what is called the recollection of the Buddha (**Buddhānussati**). That can indeed be done in that manner, not only during the leisure moments of daily travel, but even during the wasted times of wandering around; by inclining the mind to that Buddha-quality, there is an opportunity to develop the meditation subject (**kammaṭṭhāna**) one has been bringing along.

It is the same regarding the recollection of the Dhamma (**Dhammānussati**). Consider the nature of this Dhamma briefly. If we do not describe it in detail, understanding this general meaning is sufficient for someone. What is called

sati here is mindfulness. It is recollecting the Buddha, recollecting the Dhamma, recollecting the Saṅgha.

It is exactly the same with mindfulness directed to the body (*kāyagatā-sati*). This too is not something done specifically by sitting on a meditation seat. Let us say we spat or vomited. Daily bodily functions and related activities take place. On those occasions, one should not let them simply go to waste. One should not simply throw them away, calling them "waste products." One must see a Dhamma in them. One must see a Dhamma in them. Some people throw these away, calling them waste products, without deriving any benefit from them. Now, we can see in this modern scientific world that much work is done with waste products. Things we discard are sometimes taken abroad, manufactured into special products, brought back, and sold at high prices.

Then, one must think in the exact same way. We must derive benefit even from the waste products discarded from this body of ours, in accordance with the Dhamma. How do we derive benefit? We apply them to mindfulness directed to the body (*kāyagatā-sati*). Spit too is applied to *kāyagatā-sati*; feces and urine too are applied to *kāyagatā-sati*. Even at that moment, our mind is developed; it is developed through that meditation. Through that, one draws closer to Nibbāna. The attachment to *saṃsāra* decreases. The attachment to creating more and more bodily cages in this *saṃsāra* disappears. Thus, it is precisely for this reason that the Buddha has declared: "This is a Dhamma of dispassion (*virāga-dhamma*)." Within this Dhamma of the Four Noble Truths lies the departure from this *saṃsāra*. This is a journey for that purpose. Therefore, one cannot go on this journey along with attachment to it. Gradually, one must develop disenchantment (*nibbidā*) towards it. "Knowledge and vision of things as they really are" (*yathābhūta-ñāṇadassana*) means seeing the truth as it is. The Buddha has shown that disenchantment comes precisely along with seeing the truth as it is. Having seen the truth as it is, one cannot help but become disenchanted. If one sees the truth as it is to some extent, to that extent one becomes disenchanted with *saṃsāra*, disenchanted with existence (*bhava*). It is through that disenchantment that one is able to realize Nibbāna, that the door to Nibbāna opens.

Therefore, one should not be afraid of these. Whether lay or ordained, our ultimate goal is to escape from this terrifying *saṃsāra* as quickly as possible. Therefore, whatever may be the case with those household affairs, we must contemplate: "We are born alone, and we die alone." In this *saṃsāra*, we walk alone. Family relations are temporary. Therefore, our liberation belongs to us. The Buddha declares: "Not even I can liberate another; that is up to you alone." The Tathāgatas are merely teachers. Thus, this is indeed ours—this mind of ours.

In this era of a Buddha's appearance (*buddhōtpāda*), in this extremely rare opportunity of a human existence, that human mind must be applied to something highly productive. Generally, there can be many things in the world, such as profitable occupations, and so on. But those are not it. The maximum benefit to be derived from a human existence is precisely what the Buddha has shown here: he has presented them as six core virtues to be developed. Therefore, you must contemplate wisely. Many of you have a daily routine in your lifestyle. You must make an effort to add these to that daily routine. If not all six, at least a few of them. If you direct your thoughts and wishes through these channels, you will be able to awaken refreshed and joyful. You can escape from those aforementioned distressing conditions. You can draw closer to Nibbāna even faster than you thought, once these genuine inclinations are established. The Buddha has shown that there is a leading-onward nature in this Dhamma. When one engages with the Dhamma, the Dhamma itself leads one further and further forward. Why? Because the Dhamma yields benefits quickly. When one sees the benefits of the Dhamma, one is drawn further and further toward that path.

So, what we must do is recognize the true core virtues and enter upon that true path. Through that, just as the Buddha promises, we can avert the terrifying ruins in our lives and obtain a certain solace. These cannot be done with money. The secret lies right within us. Contemplating this, on a valuable day like today—this Esala Full Moon Poya day, which is an occasion when the Buddha-quality, Dhamma-quality, and Saṅgha-quality were broadcast to the entire universe, having a Dhamma-power extending from Avīci to Akaniṭṭha. Therefore, while a Buddha-power, Dhamma-power, and Saṅgha-power exist spread throughout the universe, if we spend this life dedicating our lives to trivial things, to worthless things, we alone will have to regret it.

Therefore, contemplating wisely, this merit-seeking gathering has, on this valuable day, observed a certain precept according to their respective levels, drawn close to the aforementioned path of practice, and disciplined body and speech. You have spent this time calming the mind with some such meditation. We believe that at this moment, through hearing the Dhamma (*dhamma-savana*), the factors necessary for developing the Dhamma-powers—the spiritual powers of faith, energy, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom (*saddhā, viriya, sati, samādhi, paññā*)—within your mental continuum must have been established in your mind. Likewise, through this determination you have made, may you illuminate your lives further and, through the association with noble friends (*kalyāṇa-mitta*), may this accumulated store of merit surely become a supportive condition for realizing the supreme, deathless, great Nibbāna as quickly as possible, through the penetration of the paths and fruits of Stream-

entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship (*Sotāpanna, Sakadāgāmi, Anāgāmi, Arahatta*) as declared by the Buddha!

Likewise, may all beings, whoever they may be, from Avīci to Akaniṭṭha, including the guardian deities and Brahmās of the Sāsana, and our departed relatives, rejoice in this accumulated store of merit acquired through the preaching of the Dhamma and the hearing of the Dhamma! Having rejoiced, may they all attain peace through the supreme, deathless, great Nibbāna as quickly as possible, through whichever Bodhi they have aspired to! Please share the merits with these verses.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”